

Chapter 70 - Part 4

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Xu Qingzhu and Zhou Yi'an having lunch together was actually quite a novelty.

Mainly because in this company, anyone having lunch with Zhou Yi'an was a novelty.

As everyone knew, Zhou Yi'an drove a car worth over two million to work, wore accessories that were all six figures, and her clothes cost tens of thousands.

If her personality were better, perhaps some people would want to be friends with her.

But this one was a total aloof queen¹. She never talked to people. After coming to the company, she would just sit at her workstation, draw some designs, play on her phone, and leave when it was time to clock out—never socializing with anyone.

People gave her the nickname "Loner Weirdo."

Even Lumi, known as the office's social butterfly extraordinaire², was defeated, saying this was a hard bone she couldn't gnaw through, an iceberg she couldn't melt.

Yet Xu Qingzhu went out to lunch with her at noon, at a Hunan cuisine restaurant³.

Zhou Yi'an looked at her leisurely. "What do you want to ask me?"

"Nothing." Xu Qingzhu said: "Just simply treating you to a meal to thank you for your advice this morning."

Zhou Yi'an: "....."

She had thought Xu Qingzhu couldn't resist her curiosity and was going to ask.

This feeling of having words at the tip of her tongue but being unable to say them was also quite uncomfortable.

But Zhou Yi'an didn't ask anything extra either, just ate quietly.

After they finished eating, Xu Qingzhu finally said: "You stared at me for half an hour during the meeting. What did you want to say to me?"

"Would you listen to whatever I say?" Zhou Yi'an asked back.

Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together: "Su Yao....."

This name took quite a lot of effort and courage to say from her mouth.

But she paused, then still asked: "Has she been doing well these years?"

"May I ask in what capacity are you asking?" Zhou Yi'an curved her lips, smiling quite wickedly. She pulled out a cigarette from her pocket, but after seeing Xu Qingzhu's somewhat pale face, she held the cigarette between her fingers and spun it a few times without lighting it.

However, Xu Qingzhu shrugged. "Just asking casually. If you don't want to say it, forget it. I thought you would really want to say something."

Zhou Yi'an: "....."

"Advancing by retreating⁴?" Zhou Yi'an asked.

Xu Qingzhu shook her head: "Sincere."

After saying this, she settled the bill, got up to leave. Zhou Yi'an, with her back to her, let out a light breath.

Xu Qingzhu had already walked out of the restaurant. The sky after rain was indeed much fresher.

Moreover, at this time of year, temperatures fluctuated dramatically. Yesterday it was cold at four or five degrees, but today it rose back up to over ten degrees.

The sun shone warmly on people. Xu Qingzhu's back was cool and desolate, yet extraordinarily charismatic.

Zhou Yi'an sat upstairs watching for a while. After her figure disappeared, guessing she had returned to the company, she sent her a message: 【Someone who's been living in a psychiatric hospital for years—do you think she's doing well?】

Footnotes:

¹ **Aloof queen (拽姐)** - Chinese internet slang describing a woman who is arrogant, cool, and unapproachable; someone who acts superior and doesn't associate with others easily.

² **Social butterfly extraordinaire / Social bull ceiling (社牛天花板)** - Chinese internet slang where "社牛" (social bull/cow) refers to someone extremely extroverted and socially confident, and "天花板" (ceiling) means the highest level or ultimate example. Together it means the most socially adept person possible.

³ **Hunan cuisine (湘菜)** - One of the Eight Great Traditions of Chinese cuisine, originating from Hunan province, known for its spicy and flavorful dishes using chili peppers, garlic, and shallots.

⁴ **Advancing by retreating (以退為進)** - A Chinese idiom and strategic concept meaning to make progress by appearing to withdraw; using a tactical retreat to gain advantage; making it seem like you're backing down when you're actually trying to achieve your goal through indirect means.